Laden requested asylum soon after arriving in Jalalabad, urging the Taliban to "never surrender me." Omar replied, "We will never give you up to anyone who wants you"—and stood by his promise.[50] When pressed after the two African bombings in 1998 to turn him over, Omar refused: "Even if all the countries of the world unite, we would defend Osama with our own blood."[51] In March 2001, after the United Nations had passed a half dozen resolutions demanding that Omar turn over Osama, he again refused: "Half of my country has been destroyed by two decades of war. If the remaining half is also destroyed in trying to protect Mr. bin Laden, I am willing for this sacrifice."[52]

In effect, this meant refuge not only for Osama but also for his al Qaeda followers and the thousands who would flock to train with him in the next few years. Al Qaeda was even allowed to import vehicles and equipment for their camps. The Taliban Ministry of Defense provided license plates. The national airliner, Ariana, helped bring in volunteers, guns, and money. In short, al Qaeda operated as a state within the state.[53]

In return, bin Laden and al Qaeda provided money and soldiers to help the Taliban fight their war against the Northern Alliance. Their contribution began with a few million dollars for the campaign to take and hold Kabul.[54] In time it became an annual subsidy of more than $10 million.[55] Most of this did not come from bin Laden himself because by now his access to the family fortune was limited by the Saudi authorities. But as a hero of the jihad, he retained many contacts with rich Saudis and others in the Gulf States, and he tapped this source on behalf of the Taliban.

Volunteers eager to fight with the Taliban and Pakistanis came as well. Al Qaeda formed its own unit in the Taliban army, the 55 Brigade, which by 2000 had several thousand Arabs and other Muslims under arms and was known for its ferocity on the battlefield.[56] According to French records, between 1994 and 2001, more than 1,100 French converts to Islam or young Frenchmen of North African descent alone trained in al Qaeda's camps.[57]

But the chemistry between Omar and Osama went beyond a trade of assets. Omar found in Osama and al Qaeda an ideology that transcended Afghanistan, played to his ego, and validated his role as commander of the faithful. Mullah Omar's ambitions reached far beyond wanting to be just another Pashtun warlord. With al Qaeda's support, he did indeed become far more. At the same time, his Islamic emirate became